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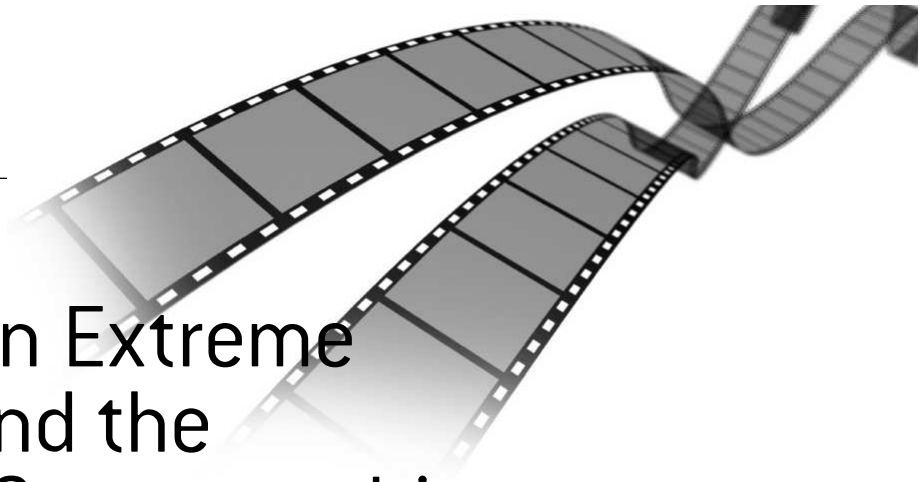

Violence in Extreme Cinema and the Ethics of Spectatorship

William Brown

My eyes persist in demanding objects that do not destroy them.
—Georges Bataille (1985: 239)

Abstract: Do films that challenge us to turn away from the screen as a result of their depictions of violence raise issues about the ethics not of regarding the pain of others, but of watching films as a whole? Drawing on Stanley Cavell's notion of revulsion, recent investigations into "extreme" cinema and, Antonin Artaud's concept of a "theater of cruelty," this article argues that watching violence on screen is not necessarily a negative and voyeuristic exercise, but that it can be good for viewers to see graphic violence on screen. This is not simply a question of viewing onscreen violence per se. What also is important is that the filmmakers adopt a set of stylistic techniques that are defined here as "cruel." Films (typically art house films) that adopt these techniques encourage viewers not to view violence for entertainment, but rather they encourage viewers to understand the potential in all humans to commit such acts. Such an understanding in turn forces us to lead our lives in an ethical fashion, whereby we do not unthinkingly follow a moral code, but rather choose and take responsibility for what we do. Furthermore, it encourages an "ethical" mode of film spectatorship in general: we watch films to learn not just voyeuristically about others, but also about what we ourselves could become.

Keywords: Stanley Cavell, cinematic violence, cruelty, ethics, *The Great Ecstasy of Robert Carmichael, A Hole in My Heart,* Pier Paolo Pasolini, spectatorship

In an essay on Dušan Makavejev and Ingmar Bergman, Stanley Cavell evokes the notion of revulsion in connection to the cinema. Certain images are revolting, Cavell argues, and to feel revolted by what we see—a woman rubbing a cock against her face in *Sweet Movie* (1974) or a monk burning himself to death in *Persona* (1966)—suggests innocence on the part of the viewer. Conversely, Cavell's reasoning is that if a viewer is *not* revolted by such images, if they do *not* turn away, then it is because that viewer has built up immunity to

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"to be revolted by revolting things suggests that one is not (yet) disillusioned with the world, that one is innocent"

the otherwise revolting world, such that she is no longer innocent, such that she is an adult (Cavell 2005: 11–39). Cavell's essay expresses some ambivalence about which is the better viewing position to adopt—to accept the world as horrible, or to be disgusted by the horrors of the world. Perhaps he comes closest to a clear position when he says that while the world may contain horrors, "it is yet more horrible to lose this capacity for horror" (Cavell 2005: 26). In other words, Cavell feels that being revolted is the preferable option; otherwise one demonstrates a total acceptance of a horrible world, an acceptance that shows we allow this world to be horrible rather than try to make it better. I want to add that in order to be revolted, *one still has to look* at the revolting and at the horrors of the world.

This article builds on Cavell's treatment of revulsion and horror, as well as the fact that we still look despite such responses to film, in order to consider the ethics of cinematic spectatorship. While films that revolt us raise issues about the ethics of regarding the pain of others (to paraphrase Susan Sontag), perhaps there are benefits to be yielded from watching horrific films—particularly those featuring violence or sexual violence. Those benefits include the possibility of reaching an ethical mode of film viewing, in which we do not watch films for pleasure/we do not necessarily take pleasure in seeing others suffer on film. Rather, we feel horror at the horrific acts that we see. Still having the capacity for horror—as opposed to feeling what we might term sadistic pleasure at seeing others suffer—becomes in this sense ethical, because it belies our continued belief in and hope for a world without horrible things, as opposed to a cynical acceptance that the world is unchangeably horrible. This ethical mode of engagement is not brought about by films featuring onscreen violence or sexual violence per se. Instead it is brought about most consciously in films that depict violence in what I term a "cruel fashion"—films in which violence is explicit, often framed in long shot, and depicted at length. Furthermore, one of the potential benefits of seeing films of this kind—even though they are not as accessible as mainstream films—is that they can bring about a more ethical engagement with cinema as a whole. The article focuses in particular on two relatively overlooked films, Thomas Clay's *The Great Ecstasy of Robert Carmichael* (2005) and Lukas Moodysson's *A Hole in My Heart* (2004).

"Still having the capacity for horror . . . becomes in this sense ethical, because it belies our continued belief in and hope for a world without horrible things"

Issues of Genre

Many scholars have written about cinematic horror, be that about horror as a genre (Hutchings 2004; Jancovich 2002), the philosophy of horror (Carroll 1990; Gaut 1993), the psychology of horror (Hills 2005), horror and psycho-

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analysis (Schneider 2004), or the study of horror from a neurological perspective (Freeland 1999). Although I use the term horror and write of horrific and horrible events, I am not expressly concerned with horror as a genre. I accept that horror as a genre holds an ongoing appeal to cinema spectators, such that horror, when felt during a film, may well be a paradoxically pleasurable experience. However, in contrast to the notion of pleasure, which is perhaps central to horror as a genre, I explore the ethics of revulsion.

If this essay is not about horror as a genre per se, but rather about the ethical benefits of feeling horror, then what might be a useful term through which we can understand the type of film I am describing? Tanya Horeck and Tina Kendall (2011) edited a collection of essays on what they term the new "extreme" in European cinema. This is not to say that the features of the new extreme are uniquely new, nor uniquely European (many Asian films and many films from before the 1990s arguably fit the bill). Nonetheless, this edited collection is useful in bringing to mind the kinds of phenomena that I wish to describe here, and which Horeck and Kendall bring together under the "extreme" umbrella. Extreme cinema consists of graphic depictions of sex, violence, and sexual violence. Extreme films are not horror films, and they do not feature the kinds of fictional monsters that we associate with horror as a genre. Nonetheless, they often horrify viewers, or induce in them feelings of revulsion such that pleasure no longer forms part of the viewing experience. A list of directors whose work is often branded extreme includes Catherine Breillat, Claire Denis, Lars von Trier, Michael Haneke, Gaspar Noé, and Ulrich Seidl. Furthermore, single films, such as *Baise-Moi* (2000), *9 Songs* (2004) and both *A Hole in My Heart* and *The Great Ecstasy of Robert Carmichael,* can be considered extreme, even though their directors are not associated uniquely with this genre.

Not all films that feature violence or sexual violence are considered extreme. An important factor to bear in mind in relation to extreme cinema is the notion of the graphic. Many of these films offer increasingly explicit representations of sex, violence, and sexual violence—such that viewers sometimes ask themselves whether in fact they are seeing a document(ary) rather than a fictional representation thereof. One of the traits of extreme cinema, then, is to blur the boundaries between art, entertainment, documentary, and pornography. When Divine eats dogshit in *Pink Flamingos* (1973), she really eats a dog turd. When the two female protagonists of *Baise-Moi* (Karen Bach and Rafaëlla Anderson) are raped, the actors simulating the rape really are aroused and they really are penetrating their victims, while on the soundtrack the actresses convincingly deliver lines to the effect that they are not consenting participants in this sexual act (for more on this aspect of the film, see Mackenzie 2002). In other words, an *enactment* of sex—with documentary-level claims to truth—is used to enhance the realism of a *representation* of rape,

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thereby blurring the boundaries between representations of events and events themselves. Other recent films that achieve this to differing degrees include *The Idiots* (1998), *Dog Days* (2001), *Irréversible* (2001), *The Brown Bunny* (2003), *Import/Export* (2007), as well as *9 Songs, A Hole in My Heart* and *The Great Ecstasy of Robert Carmichael*. While all of these films are constructions, their sexually explicit nature makes it difficult to tell false from real—precisely because what we see often did actually happen in front of the camera.

"it is often difficult to tell false from real when watching extreme cinema – precisely because what we see sometimes did actually happen in front of the camera"

If there is a paradoxical pleasure to be gained from watching horror films, one that is built upon knowing that the horror film is a construct, then this contemporary form of extreme film perhaps constitutes a new genre—one designed specifically to make us question our enjoyment of viewing horrific acts, particularly in a world where images of cruelty abound. These films achieve this by putting into question the constructed nature of what it is that we are seeing, thereby inducing feelings not of paradoxical pleasure, but of revulsion, horror, and disgust. Given the explicit documentary-style depiction of the violent content, the issue of cinematic realism thus becomes a pressing one. These films are not simply or uniquely concerned with showing explicit violent acts; they often, and perhaps most powerfully, show these explicit violent acts in a particular style. We shall discuss the nature of this style shortly. But at present we must bear in mind that the very existence of an "extreme cinema" style suggests that cinema remains a medium—and that an awareness of the mediated nature of what we are seeing is perhaps key to the ethical engagement that these films seem to encourage. For, watching penetrative sex, violence or sexual violence via the medium of cinema is not the same as watching for pleasure or for the sake of curiosity live sex shows, pugilistic combat, war, bullfighting, rape, and torture, whether organized or not, whether legal or not. Each of these has its own ethical concerns, into which I cannot delve here. What is important is that while scenes of explicit sexual violence do make us question the veridical nature or otherwise of the image, it is the mediated nature of what we are seeing that helps bring us toward an ethical engagement with the image. If it is not just the explicit nature of what we see, but also the way in which these explicit acts are depicted that is important for bringing us toward an ethical engagement with film, then it is through a consideration of cinematic "cruelty" that we can begin to approach what those techniques are.

A Cinema of Cruelty

Given that Antonin Artaud was a "madman" (Nelson 2011: 5), it is not surprising that his writings are the source of some confusion. Nonetheless, in calling for a "theater of cruelty," Artaud demanded not simply plays that were filled

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with blood, but plays that were "difficult and cruel first of all for myself" (1976: 256). It is hard to understand precisely what Artaud means, but he claims that theater, when used in "the highest and most difficult possible sense, has the power to influence the aspect and formation of things" (Ibid.). In other words, Artaud seems to call for a theater that does not simply show us the world as it is, but which can take part in shaping the world that we inhabit.

That said, Artaud does suggest that theater can practice on us a "terrible and necessary cruelty," which is to make us realize the following: "We are not free. And the sky can still fall on our heads. And the theater has been created, first of all, to teach us that" (1976: 256). Artaud seems to suggest that theater, which here includes cinema, can teach us that we are all capable of cruelty, and that violent acts are not simply the remit of "bad" people, but of all people. Paradoxically, realizing that we are all capable of violence/cruelty creates the conditions for us to lead an ethical life, one in which we understand that of which we are capable.

Artaud (1976: 250) suggests that cinema offers a "crude visualization of what is," while theater provides us with "images of what is not"—the implication being that theater is live, and thus alive, while cinema is constrained to celluloid and thus somehow dead. However, Artaud perhaps underestimates cinema here. In terms of the above argument regarding realism and medium awareness, the power of cinema is perhaps most forceful at moments—especially those involving violence—when we are not sure whether what we are seeing is or is not real, or what for Artaud is live/alive. Artaud suggests that cruelty is "at the foundation of every spectacle" and that without it "the theater is not possible" (Ibid.: 251). I would argue that this is equally true of cinema, but that only certain films, with films depicting explicit violence or sexual violence *in a certain fashion* here serving to bring out what cinema can do more forcefully. And what cinema can do is akin to what theater can do for Artaud: namely, it is "through the skin that metaphysics will be made to reenter our minds" (Ibid.). What this means is that cinema comes into its own when it makes us question who we are ("metaphysics"), and it achieves this not necessarily through abstract philosophical works, but "through the skin"—through works that provide not abstracted/detached viewing pleasure, but which induce in us the physical sensation of revulsion.

"cinema comes into its own when it makes us question who we are . . . it achieves this through works that induce in us the physical sensation of revulsion"

Although he does not refer specifically to Artaud, André Bazin (1982: 3–12) uses the term "cinema of cruelty" to define the cinema of Erich von Stroheim and Luis Buñuel, among others. Bazin praises von Stroheim in particular for rejecting the typical narrative techniques, especially the cut, associated with D.W. Griffith, and for showing instead of telling. Cruelty for Bazin, then, involves showing; it is an explicit cinema that stylistically involves a rejection of narrative techniques, of the cut, and thus of telling, and instead involves continuity, or an absence of the cut.

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William Blum (1971), meanwhile, has directly taken Artaud as the inspiration for his own "cinema of cruelty," although for Blum it is not von Stroheim but Sam Peckinpah, particularly through his film *The Wild Bunch* (1969), who serves as a template for the cruel cinema that he describes. Blum praises Peckinpah for putting into practice what Artaud demands and for looking frankly at mankind and all that of which he is capable in the hope of "affecting the organism" into change. In other words, Peckinpah, whose cinema is associated with extreme violence, helps to bring about the kind of metaphysical thought that Artaud believes is the function of the theater of cruelty. And he achieves this by making explicit the violence that he depicts, most famously through his use of slow motion shots during scenes of gruesome violence.

Peckinpah's *The Wild Bunch* is a film that features some 3,000 shots—far more than many of the other Hollywood films of the period. As such, if Bazin admires in von Stroheim the absence of Griffithian narrative, which loosely he sees as associated with editing and cutting, then *The Wild Bunch* would not at first blush qualify as "cruel" cinema for Bazin, even if it does for Blum. Indeed, rather than rejecting narrative and the continuity editing that is Griffith's stylistic legacy, *The Wild Bunch* would in fact seem to qualify as an example of what Bordwell (2006) has termed the *intensification* of continuity editing. However, rather than necessarily contradicting Bazin's cinema of cruelty, Blum's inclusion of *The Wild Bunch* in his own cinema of cruelty does share with Bazin's a propensity to show, with the slow motion functioning as a marked example of this; telling/narrative is suspended as Peckinpah makes us watch extreme violence at great length. In this way, the slow motion shots in *The Wild Bunch* do involve an absence of cuts in accordance with what Bazin admires in von Stroheim, and which perhaps are more powerful in *The Wild Bunch* precisely because the moments of slow motion stand in such stark contrast to the rapid editing of the rest of the film.

"an absence of cuts, in combination with content that is (sexually) violent, can help to bring about an ethical mode of film viewing"

In order to explore how an absence of cuts, in combination with content that is (sexually) violent, can help to bring about an ethical mode of film viewing, I analyze Thomas Clay's little-known but harrowing film, *The Great Ecstasy of Robert Carmichael* (2005).

The Great Ecstasy of Robert Carmichael

The Great Ecstasy of Robert Carmichael tells the story of Robert (Daniel Spencer), a bored teenage boy in a coastal town in southern England. Robert is good at the cello, but does not really engage with the world around him. He takes drugs and is witness to a gang rape at one moment in the film, and toward the film's end he takes part in a vicious rape and murder. Both violent scenes come as if from nowhere, and are deeply disturbing and revolting as a

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result. However, what inspires revulsion is not uniquely the acts of rape and murder, but also the way in which the scenes are shot.

During the first rape scene ex-convict Larry (Danny Dyer) and Robert's classmate Ben (Charles Mnene) rape Marie (Ami Instone) in an adjoining bedroom while Robert watches BBC News 24 and its coverage of the Iraq war on TV (the film is set in 2003). During the second rape and murder scene, Robert violates Monica (Miranda Wilson) with a bottle and a sculpture in the form of a spike. During the first scene, the camera slowly tracks around the room in which Robert watches television, and during the second scene everything is shown in a static long shot. Both scenes signally fail to cut. It is this failure to cut and the film's insistence on showing that not only makes them most revolting, but which also encourages an ethical engagement with the film.

We can perhaps better understand how this comes about in Clay's film by looking at Torben Grodal's consideration of the films of Lars von Trier. Grodal writes that optical distance from events, in the form of long shots, diminishes and slows down the audience's empathic response to the events depicted. When, as in the films of von Trier, the events depicted also involve scenes of perverse sexuality, then the result is what Grodal calls "perverse scenes [that] block the narrative and empathic identification and, hence, the build up of emotions; the viewer is placed as a distant observer who eventually activates feelings. Perversion is therefore one of many ways of creating lyrical-saturated experiences" (2004: 154). *Robert Carmichael* can be thought to work in a similarly "perverse" fashion: it is not a film that cues much empathy with the characters, particularly because the camera, especially during the moments of extreme violence, keeps its distance or moves in a very self-conscious manner. As a result, we are less "involved" in the scenes emotionally and are encouraged instead to feel aware of our position as spectators. This is not the pleasurable voyeurism that was popular as a theoretical model for film viewing in the 1970s (see, for the most prominent example, Mulvey 1975). Rather, it is a deeply unpleasurable looking, one that I am characterizing as revulsion. And revulsion encourages an ethical engagement with the film, because, by virtue of our watching the scene despite our lack of pleasure, we must ask why we are watching.

"Robert Carmichael does not cue much empathy with the characters, because the camera keeps its distance and/or moves in a very self-conscious manner"

As the camera drifts through the apartment during the first rape scene, the camera does not so much follow the characters as make its way through the space, drawing our attention away from the characters and to the camera itself. This brings to our attention our position as spectators, an effect that is reinforced at the scene's end when the camera comes to rest in a long shot of an indifferent Robert, his back to us, watching TV as Marie is raped in the next room. This final composition heightens the link—in a revolting fashion—

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between Robert as spectator and us as spectators. Jarring and aggressive techno music muffling the sounds of abuse makes the scene even more uncomfortable. We grow angry that Robert does nothing to stop the rape; both the rape itself and Robert's lack of reaction to it are disturbing. The unendurable length of the scene means that a further, ethical question must be asked: Should I be disturbed that I am prepared to put up with and endure this scene myself as a viewer? Why am I watching this? Or, put another way, because he is watching the scene in the same manner that I am, am I just like, or could I be, Robert?

"put another way, because he is watching the scene in the same that I am, am I just like, or could I be, Robert?"

The second rape and murder scene is filmed almost exclusively in long shot, with an immobile camera. Here the cruelty of the scene is even more deliberate: a brutal rape and murder that also becomes unendurable is shot in a deliberate "art house" manner. In other words, both scenes not only feature acts of perversion, but they are also shot in a deliberately "perverse" manner. That is, the "lyrical" camerawork in both scenes works "against" the otherwise sadistic/pornographic content, which might, in the hands of other directors, be shot in a manner to match what stereotypically would be the hysteria of the participants. It is this combination of an art house style and the explicit and violent content that helps to induce an ethical engagement with the film.

Grodal seems to reinforce this point when he writes: "The film [*The Idiots*] in some sense enhances the cueing of shame and embarrassment in the viewer, because the realist setting makes some of the sex scenes and the scenes where the characters play mentally retarded more embarrassing" (2004: 159). Grodal suggests that the contrast between film style (in the case of *The Idiots,* shaky, handheld DV cameras) and film content (sex and "spassing"—the name that the protagonists give to their moments of pretending to be mentally retarded) can make audiences uncomfortable, inducing in them shame and embarrassment (see also Laine 2007: 73–76). I suggest that Clay

Figure 1: "Perverse" long shot #2: Robert and his accomplices rape and murder Monica and Jonathan (Michael Howe)

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and cinematographer Giorgos Arvanitis, who has worked with art house director Theo Angelopoulos and French "extreme" filmmaker Catherine Breillat, achieve a similar effect, except that here they mix self-conscious camerawork with extreme violence, inducing not just discomfort in the audience, but making them question why they are putting up with this discomfort at all.

Finally, of *Dogville* (2003), Grodal writes:

> *Whereas the emotional frame of the film is composed of irony, the content is also imparted with aggression that leads to humiliation and sexual perversion. The story about how Grace is put in chains and forced to have sex with all the men in the village—and in a way also in full public view because of the lacks [sic] of walls—is a slightly veiled pornographic story. However, the story is provided with a context that transforms arousal into shame, embarrassment, and empathy. (2004: 164)*

Again, we can compare Grodal's analysis of von Trier's work with *The Great Ecstasy of Robert Carmichael*: the aggressive content is imparted in an incongruous "art house" style, meaning that this is *not* pornography, but a moment that is impossible (I suspect) to enjoy. This incongruity is an important part of the ambiguity that I mentioned earlier as important for the ethical engagement that I am describing. Perhaps we feel ashamed to watch these scenes, but more than this, we feel revulsion, in part as a result of the ambiguous/incongruous style—and yet we keep on watching, which leads us toward the ethical engagement already mentioned.

The Ethics of Spectatorship

The second rape scene in *Robert Carmichael* features insert shots of archive footage of Britain during World War II, while the first sees Robert watch BBC News 24 coverage of the Iraq war. These and other repeated references to armed conflict, together with a rather strained and self-reflexive scene in which a film class discusses the depiction of violence and war in cinema, suggests a link between war, the media, and a society seemingly in collapse, in that it produces "monsters" like Robert. Although *Robert Carmichael* involves some of the most harrowing images I have seen in a fiction film, the film seems to imply a rejection of the politicized and mediatized violence of the contemporary world. If, then, *Robert Carmichael* is a rejection of the world as it is, and if to be an adult one must accept the world as it is, then we can class the film as "innocent" despite its "adult" content. The film's "innocence" might help to explain why some critics have considered the film naive (e.g., Gilbey 2006). However, I would argue that *Robert Carmichael* is self-consciously naive, precisely to help encourage the ethical engagement that I am describing.

"Robert Carmichael is self-consciously naïve, precisely to help encourage the ethical engagement that I am describing"

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Perhaps a clue to the self-conscious nature of *Robert Carmichael*'s naïveté lies in director Clay's decision to name his production company Boudu Films. This name recalls Jean Renoir's great *Boudu Saved from Drowning* (1932), in which the eponymous tramp (Michel Simon) is taken into the home of the bourgeois Lestingois family after attempting suicide by throwing himself into the Seine. Throughout the film, Boudu asks naive questions that point to the absurd nature of behavior that otherwise has been naturalized in the Lestingois household. Could we not also argue that *The Great Ecstasy of Robert Carmichael* functions as a whole in the way that Boudu does in Renoir's film? That is, the film poses the naive but fundamentally unsettling questions: Why is the world the way that it is? Why are we surrounded by screens, why do we watch them, and why do they show so much violence?

"Why are we surrounded by screens, why do we watch them, and why do they show so much violence?"

The "innocent" rejection of the contemporary world that *Robert Carmichael* entails is arguably matched by the "innocence" of those viewers who are revolted by the film to such an extent that they leave without seeing it through to the end. However, those viewers who do finish watching the film, while "adult" in the sense given here, might also begin themselves to ask the kind of "innocent" questions that the film seems to: Could I be (like) Robert? Why is the world as it is such that people like Robert might exist? Why is it that films featuring such extreme violence exist? And why am I watching this film despite being revolted by it? These questions are core to an ethical engagement with the film, which we can align with the metaphysical dimension of Artaud's theater of cruelty.

Film scholars have generally centered investigations into the ethical dimensions of film either on issues of identification with "moral" or "immoral" characters within films (see Stadler 2002), or on the ethics of the filmmaker, particularly from the anthropological perspective within documentary (see Cooper 2006). Downing and Saxton (2010: 74, 88) have, meanwhile, raised questions concerning the viewer's willing participation in the staging of pain for entertainment, as well as about the "reality" status or otherwise of representations, particularly in relation to *Baise-Moi*. However, none of these scholars looks specifically at revulsion and the role that it might play in the ethics of spectatorship. Meanwhile, Susan Sontag's *Regarding the Pain of Others* (2003) deals in great detail with affect (what happens when we regard the pain of others), but it does not delve too deeply into the moral/ethical dilemma raised here: *should* we regard this pain?

Maggie Nelson does address this question, predominantly in relation to performance art from the 1960s on. When she (briefly) turns her attention to cinema, she argues that violent films like *City of God* (2002) are "designed to exhilarate as much as brutalize its audience" (2011: 252), and that in such films, "violence or cruelty does not enlighten" and "neither I nor the world will

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be a better place if I ingest a particular cruelty" (2011: 97, 253). Although I share with Nelson the contention that much cinema does suffer from attempting to exhilarate or induce pleasure in its audience when depicting violence, the cruel cinema that I am considering here, and which Nelson overlooks is, unlike *City of God,* designed specifically not to exhilarate, but can instead induce an ethical engagement with the film in question, and with film viewing more generally.

Having said that ingesting a particular cruelty does not make her or the world a better place, Nelson parenthetically adds regarding *City of God*: "Then, of course, I ingested it anyway, as per the implacable imperative of the cinema, especially the cinema of cruelty. *Bam* [*sic*]" (2011: 253). From a single example Nelson extrapolates something general about cinema ("the implacable imperative of the cinema") before specifying that there is a set of films that constitutes a "cinema of cruelty," without analyzing how she gets from one to the other. *City of God,* with its graphic depiction of violence arguably tempered by its stylized look, is perhaps only questionably a cruel film: it *does* seek to exhilarate its viewers. Conversely, *Robert Carmichael* revolts its viewers, making it more certainly a cruel film as I am using the term here.

Nelson's turn to the personal response ("I ingested it anyway") is not unique. *The Art of Cruelty* is full of first person responses to performance art and other works, while Blum also uses the term confession when dealing with responses to what he terms ultra-violent cinema:

> *To watch The Wild Bunch demands much more than an open, objective mind. It requires a difficult confession, and a vast amount of courage. Submitting to the experience of a work of Cruelty acknowledges, and such a work insists, that you are not your own man, that forces exist inside you and beyond your control, forces that can make you tear out a man's throat or burn his children. If a man's image of himself is his protection against this reality, then it suits that image for a man to be repelled by the killing in The Wild Bunch. (1971: 33)*

Blum articulates quite closely the ethical engagement that cruel cinema encourages: he understands that he could be as violent and horrible as the members of the wild bunch themselves. With regard to my own response to *The Great Ecstasy of Robert Carmichael* I, like Nelson, did not leave the room or even close my eyes. Like Nelson, I "ingested" the film. If truly I was revolted when viewing these moments, then I would, as the word implies, have turned away (re-volted). But I, and many other spectators (though certainly not all) do not, or did not, turn away. The question raised, then, is why? We can address this question through a consideration of revulsion and Lukas Moodysson's *A Hole in My Heart*.

"If truly I was revolted when viewing these moments, then I would, as the word implies, have turned away (re-volted)"

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A Hole in My Heart

Is it the case that, following Cavell's criteria, I am *not* innocent, for I can ingest/do not turn away from what these films show me? Not only can I ingest it, but to a certain extent I go looking for it. Revulsion takes its root from *revellere,* the Latin verb meaning "to pull." *Revellere* is also the root of the more upbeat term, to revel. Given the etymological link between revulsion and revelling, then, perhaps I *do* feel revulsion of a sort, in that I *revel* in these images, as opposed to turning away, revolted. I do not want to endure these films repeatedly. Indeed, in this sense, I am like Carl Plantinga who says that "while I may admire Martin Scorsese's *Raging Bull* as a work of art, I may nonetheless limit my viewings because its brutality and graphic violence disturb me" (1997: 382). That said, I have no fear of "extreme" films. Indeed, I feel myself obliged somewhat to go watch the latest offerings, even if those films are by definition not very mainstream or well known. In fact, it follows that these films are not very well known precisely because they are very hard to watch, because they induce revulsion in many viewers, and because films that do not please viewers logically receive predominantly poor reviews. However, what I wish to emphasize is that while I do not always *like* what I see, I do not turn away. I am instead glued to the screen; I *revel* in the images. That is, I persist not out of a sense of viewing pleasure, but out of a sense of viewing displeasure that is far removed from the paradoxes of horror as a genre. Cruel, or extreme, cinema does not induce a paradoxical pleasure—even though some viewers may watch *Baise-Moi* as pornography, as personal conversation with other viewers has suggested. Rather, it prompts the ethical considerations I have discussed above and which I clarify below through a consideration of *A Hole in My Heart*.

"while I don't always like what I see, I do not turn away. I am instead glued to the screen; I revel in the images"

As mentioned, Cavell (2005: 25–26) says that the performance of ugly and indecent acts is in part a rejection of a disgusting world and that to accept the world in all of its hideousness is a sign of adulthood, a sign of the end of innocence. In "accepting" *Baise-Moi* and *The Great Ecstasy of Robert Carmichael* by watching them in their entirety, I give consent to them to exist as they are. I am in this sense an "adult" spectator who accepts these films. The way in which adults look at the world as it is ("unadulterated"?), rather than refusing to contemplate parts of it, is a central theme in *A Hole in My Heart*.

In Moodysson's difficult film, pornographers Rickard (Thorsten Flinck), Geko (Goran Marjanoviç), and Tess (Sanna Bråding) undergo a process of exposing some of the darkest elements of their personalities to each other as they make a porn film that involves scat elements, including a quasi-rape scene and an orgy in which the characters drink each other's vomit and urine. However, at the end of the film, these characters also seem to emerge as a would-be coherent group, as is signaled by their tactile relationship. This group bonding, no matter how perverse and at times unpleasant, can be com-

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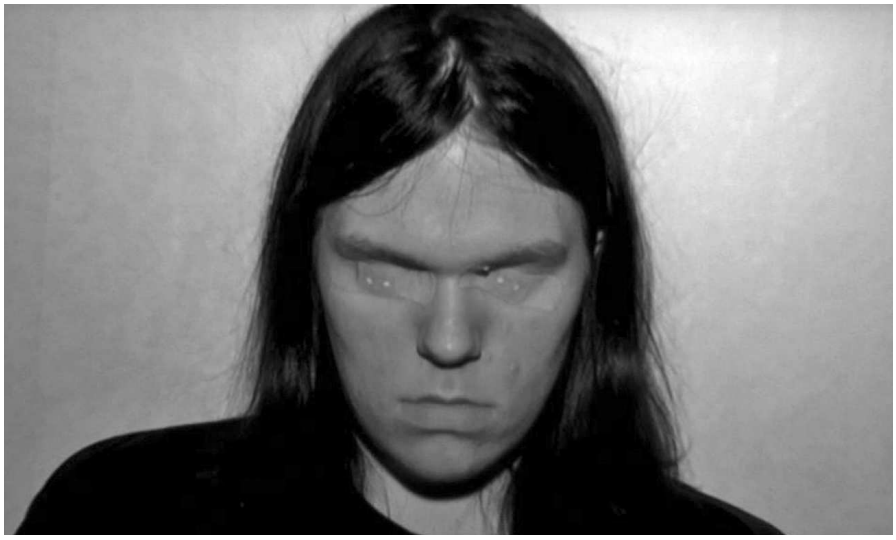

Figure 2: The revolted, innocent child: Rickard's son, Eric, covers his eyes with plasters so as not to see in A Hole in My Heart

pared to the experiences of Rickard's son, Eric (Björn Almroth), who refuses to engage with the adults and remains a solipsist in his room. The film seems to suggest that only when we are prepared to look at and to accept ourselves for who we are, no matter how unpleasant elements of this might be, can we properly claim to know and understand each other. To hide away from the "dark" elements of the world is not to engage with the world in a frank and positive manner.

Blum argues that "Artaud's theater does not shun or minimize the complexity of man, but shows and suggests to him everything he is, and impels him to participate to the limits of his potentiality in the totality of his being. This totality includes propensities destructive to life and society" (1971: 22). Meanwhile, Cavell (2005:24), quoting Henry David Thoreau, implies that monstrous death is proof of a superabundance of life. In other words, where Blum recognizes that humanity is capable of both good and horrible deeds, Cavell also suggests that the monstrous is not separate to humanity, but part of humanity—a suggestion that in some ways distances cruel or extreme cinema from horror as a genre, because horror so often projects the monstrous on to supernatural beings. For Cavell the monstrous is in fact natural, with the Marquis de Sade functioning as a key example of how monsters are not inhuman but precisely all too human. It is in understanding this that our ethical engagement with a film can begin—and this reflection is encouraged not by films that seek to exhilarate or titillate, but by films that show and which do so in the sober if cruel fashion that I have tried to describe. This reflection is encouraged not by films that are easy to ingest, but which are precisely hard to swallow. It is by exploring the association between films and/as food that I wish to continue my exploration of the ethics of spectatorship.

"the monstrous is not separate to humanity, but part of humanity"

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Film and/as Food

If Nelson speaks of "ingesting" art works as a spectator, then Lukas Moodysson also describes *A Hole in My Heart* as a "meal" that he cannot chew for his spectators (see Anonymous 2004). Another filmmaker who describes his films as meals for audiences to consume is Pier Paolo Pasolini, with *Salò, or the 120 Days of Sodom* (1975) most powerfully and distastefully demonstrating the cinema and/as food paradigm through its biting analysis of humanity's willingness, literally, to consume shit. Indeed, Pasolini himself describes *Salò* as being about how producers force consumers to eat excrement (see Bachmann and Pasolini 1975).

That I managed to ingest/eat *Salò* perhaps means that the film failed, because maybe the appropriate response to the film is to gag and rush from the auditorium. Nonetheless, even if I did not look away, *Salò* did horrify me, such that I realize I have not lost the capacity for horror, which in turn means that I might yet help to reduce the horrors of the world, rather than accepting the world and all its horrors as inevitable and unchangeable. This viewing position is not one typically encouraged by countless action films that invite me to take active pleasure in the violence that they depict, and in such a way that I do not question that of which humanity is capable (I accept and enjoy human violence, rather than question it).

It is surely no coincidence that Robert Carmichael masturbates while reading a dog-eared copy of de Sade's *Salò* some halfway through *The Great Ecstasy of Robert Carmichael*. Like de Sade, that monster who is all too human in Cavell's eyes, Robert is also a monster who is all too human and natural, an impression that is reinforced by the film's final shot, which depicts Robert and his friends walking through the English countryside, as if part of nature. In this final shot, Robert is walking away from the camera, his back to us. In other words, he is enacting precisely the motion that we should have done if were we truly revolted by this film. Instead, we are still in our seats watching, and this in itself seems to affirm that Robert is not an unnatural monster whom we can dismiss as unreal, unrealistic, or supernatural, but who is already in here, in us, potentially if not actually. Our eyes see what Robert does and they may be revolted by it; but our eyes also show through the very act of looking that the monster is within, that we could ourselves be Robert. In making this realization, we are asked to adopt an ethical viewing position, not strictly to condemn Robert for the bad deeds he perpetrates, but rather to realize that we, too, could be Robert. In realizing that we share with Robert the potential to commit atrocities, we are in a better position to choose not to, and in this way we can lead a more ethical life.

"our eyes also show through the very act of looking that the monster is within"

I have insisted repeatedly that the ethical engagement with cruel cinema is one that can apply to cinema viewing as a whole. What I mean by this is that once we have seen a film like *Robert Carmichael,* and once we have en-

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Figure 3: As if their monstrosity were natural, Robert and his accomplices walk away from the camera, surrounded by nature in The Great Ecstasy of Robert Carmichael

gaged with it in the fashion that I am describing here, then we can carry forward the ethical mode of viewing and bring it to all films that we see. That is, we can begin to see all films from the ethical perspective, such that we view all films in terms of showing us that of which mankind is capable, that of which we ourselves might also be capable. Furthermore, it may encourage in us a desire to see films that seem themselves to adopt a more ethical stance towards their subject matter. That is, to see films that do not necessarily ask us to take pleasure in screen violence, but which approach violence in a more responsible fashion.

I do not suggest that one cannot enjoy fantastic screen violence. Nor do I wish to suggest that screen violence cannot function as some sort of release or substitute for the impulse to commit violent acts in the real world. However, such important debates are not my concern here. My concern here has rather been to explore the ethics of film spectatorship in relation to the extreme cinema of cruelty that is characterized not only by explicit violence or sexual violence, but which also depicts such acts in a "cruel" fashion, namely through an absence of cuts, with long shot, and extended duration being common features thereof. Such film "meals" are hard to ingest, and as such an extreme cinema of cruelty will perhaps never be as prominent or popular as mainstream blockbusters. Given the imbalance in numbers between those who watch mainstream blockbusters and those who watch extreme and cruel films, perhaps highlighting the potential benefits of the latter can in some small way help to redress this imbalance, even if never eradicate it. But this ethical mode of engagement is not necessarily easy. As explained above, it involves viewing difficult films and understanding that we could be like the violent characters within them. It involves understanding that we all have the capacity for monstrous behavior and that monsters are all too human, as opposed to being inhuman or supernatural. This is difficult because it asks us to view ourselves as potentially very bad, violent people. But the benefits—an

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ethical life in which we choose not to be violent—perhaps outweigh the difficulties.

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Note

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